# FOOD POWER

## THE RISE AND FALL OF THE POSTWAR AMERICAN FOOD SYSTEM

BRYAN L. McDONALD

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OXFORD
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Published in the United States of America by Oxford University Press
198 Madison Avenue, New York, NY 10016, United States of America.

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Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data
Names: McDonald, Bryan (Bryan L.), author.
Title: Food power : the rise and fall of the postwar American food system / Bryan L. McDonald.
Description: New York, NY : Oxford University Press, [2017] |
Includes bibliographical references and index.
Identifiers: LCCN 2016021508 (print) | LCCN 2016033628 (ebook) |
ISBN 9780190600686 (hardcover : alk. paper) | ISBN 9780190600693 (Updf) |
ISBN 9780190600709 (Epub)
Subjects: LCSH: Agriculture and state—United States—History—20th century. |
Agriculture—Economic aspects—United States—History—20th century. |
Agriculture and politics—United States—History—20th century. |
Food supply—United States—History—20th century. |
Food security—United States—History—20th century. | United States—Foreign relations.
Classification: LCC HD1761 .M26 2017 (print) | LCC HD1761 (ebook) |
DDC 338.1/97309045—dc23
LC record available at https://lccn.loc.gov/2016021508

9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Printed by Sheridan Books, Inc., United States of America

*For my parents*

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# ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This book was conceived and written at Penn State University and its nature and responsibilities as a land-grant institution—and my resulting ability to draw on colleagues from humanities, social sciences, and agricultural sciences—deeply informed my thinking as I wrote. In the Penn State history department, I want to thank William Blair, Gary Cross, Greg Eghigian, Lori Ginzberg, Amy Greenberg, Tony Kaye, Ari Kelman, and Michael Kulikowski. I am also grateful to other colleagues at Penn State who provided encouragement from a variety of perspectives and helped ensure the fidelity of my reading across disciplines, including Mia Bloom, Leland Glenna, John Horgan, Jonathan Marks, Anastasia Shcherbakova, Susan Squier, Donald Thompson, Nancy Tuana, and Steve Walton. I am especially grateful to Eric Novotny and the staff at the Penn State University Libraries for their assistance in locating sources and unearthing needed materials from the archives. I also appreciate the helpful advice and support from scholars outside Penn State and across diverse disciplines, including Kent Hughes Butts, Nick Cullather, Geoff Dabelko, Gregory Domber, Kristin Hoganson, Sheyda Jahanbani, Tim Luke, Richard Matthew, Char Miller, Adam Rome, and Ken Rutherford.

I received research support from a number of sources that greatly facilitated the completion of this book. I am particularly thankful for resources provided by an Early Career Professorship in the Rock Ethics Institute that was made possible by a generous gift from Douglas and Joyce Sherwin. I also received support from the Department of History at Penn State and

the Haag Family Fund at Penn State. Important work on this manuscript was completed during a one semester residential fellowship from the Penn State's Institute for Arts and the Humanities and I am grateful for the support and community provided by the Institute.

I am grateful for helpful comments provided by anonymous reviewers from Oxford University Press. Their suggestions helped enormously in improving the final manuscript. Susan Ferber at Oxford University Press was an outstanding editor and I appreciate her diligence and assistance with the development of this book. I am also grateful to Maya Bringe from Newgen North America for her assistance in moving the book through the production process.

I also want to thank my family for their love and support during the writing of this book.

# Food Power

# Introduction

## *Food Power, the Food Network, and American Security*

In 1951, the Czekalinski family of Cleveland, Ohio, posed in a photo depicting all the food they might eat in a year. Gathered in the cold-storage locker of the West Ninth Street warehouse of the Great Atlantic and Pacific Tea Company, Steve, his wife Stephanie, and their sons Stephen and Henry wore coats against the cold and were surrounded by two and a half tons of food, including 698 quarts of milk, 578 pounds of meat, 131 dozen eggs, 56 pounds of butter, 72 pounds of shortening, 180 loaves of bread, more than 1,000 pounds of vegetables, and 400 pounds of fresh fruit, plus sugar, flour, cereal, coffee, and more. Steve, who worked in the shipping department of DuPont's Cleveland plant, earned $1.95 an hour, and the family spent about $25 a week, or $1,300 a year, on food.[1]

The photo and accompanying article, "Why We Eat Better," were conceived by public relations officials at DuPont for their internal magazine, *Better Living*, in order to show the bounty of foods available to an average American industrial worker with an average size family. The photo of the Czekalinski family was the centerpiece of the article, positioned on a two-page spread that also included insets showing the foods that were unavailable to the families of average workers in England, Belgium, Germany, Poland, and China.[2] The picture was subsequently printed in *Life* in 1951, reprinted or described in a number of newspapers in the early 1950s, used again by DuPont in 1975, and then selected in 1998 by Harold Evans, the

editor of *U.S. News & World Report*, as the image of the century.[3] In addition to being compelling, this photo of an American family surrounded by food is also a clear reminder that food, beyond providing sustenance, can also have a role in politics, in this case, by demonstrating the superiority of the American way in providing a modern standard of living. The food in the photograph is not just a backdrop—it is an embodiment of the power of the United States in the years after World War II.

The use of food as an element of national power is often discussed under the concept of "food power." For Americans in the years after World War II, food power could be used as a demonstration of the good life that was enjoyed by a larger and larger number of people. As revealed by the enduring relevance of the 1951 photograph of the Czekalinski family and their food, the demonstration of abundance, prosperity, and stability through food was a powerful message, both to Americans at home and for people of many nations abroad. Food was an integral part of President Roosevelt's vision for a world that enjoyed "freedom from want," one of the four essential freedoms he identified as the framework for postwar lives of plenty and prosperity, which would ensure peace and security for all the world.[4]

Food power, of course, could also be used coercively. In 1974, Earl Butz, secretary of agriculture in the Nixon administration, described food as a weapon that could be used to achieve American national objectives.[5] A postwar agricultural revolution had filled the silos and storage facilities in America with food. Changes in agriculture and food production resulted in so much food that for most of the three decades after the end of the war, Americans grappled with food, not as an asset, but as a problem. A surplus of food—including staple crops like corn and wheat but also milk, butter, and meat—depressed farm prices and hurt rural prosperity while raising the costs of federal farm programs and food-storage efforts.

By the 1970s, Butz realized that this surplus food, far more than was needed to fulfill even America's growing needs, could be a valuable weapon in the arsenal of democracy at a time when the global need for food was rising. In 1976, Butz noted that he had heard a Communist counterpart say, "You have something more powerful than atom bombs. You have

protein."[6] Communists weren't the only ones to recognize the importance of American food power. As Butz told a reporter with *Time*, his influence with both American and foreign diplomatic officials increased considerably during the 1970s because when he came "calling with wheat in my pocket, they pay attention."[7] Food was always valuable, but in the wake of a global food crisis from 1972 to 1974, there was renewed attention to the link between food and security. Food power, to many American policymakers, represented "the diplomatic influence that a food-exporting country exercises over the decisions and activities of other nations because of the control (either actual or perceived) that the exporting country has over a specific market or segment of a market, or as a concomitant to the ability of the food-exporting country to provide food aid to needy countries."[8] Food power could be deployed indirectly, in the form of trade or humanitarian assistance, or directly, in the form of giving or withholding food in times of crisis.

During the first three decades of the Cold War, Americans struggled to understand how food could best be used as an element of national power. Advocates of the food-as-a-weapon approach placed food alongside other desirable commodities, such as natural resources or military and industrial technology, seeing it as a vital substance that could be used to gain an advantage in foreign relations. During the world food crisis in the 1970s, the important and outsized role of the United States in global food export markets became clear. Some officials felt food gave the United States a powerful tool to use in forcing countries to adopt policy positions favored by the United States. Learning from the cavalier way the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) had used oil as a weapon against supporters of Israel in the 1973 Yom Kippur War, one senior State Department official summarized the food-as-a-weapon approach with the blunt assessment that "we have the food, and the hell with the rest of the world."[9] Other officials confirmed that American policymakers had considered using a food embargo in response to the oil shutoff.[10] In this sense, food power was seen in a limited way, the ability to manipulate international transfers of food in order to accomplish diplomatic goals.[11]

But the opportunities to use food power in such an openly coercive way were limited. They required that the United States have large amounts of surplus food available for export. They required, further, that other sources of food were not available, something hard to guarantee during a time when Canada, Australia, and Argentina were also regularly producing bountiful surpluses. Coercion also clashed with view that access to food was something to which all people had a right. The status of food as a human right was affirmed in the 1948 Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which stated, "Everyone has the right to a standard of living adequate for the health and well-being of himself and of his family, including food."[12] Thus, though food could be conceptualized as a lever of coercive power, in practice, American leaders and policymakers found food to be more useful as a softer form of power, deployed through the avenues of trade or foreign assistance.[13] Power, in international relations, can be defined as the ability to influence the behavior of others in order to achieve a desired outcome. It is generally measured with reference to such criteria as the population size, geography, natural resources, economic strength, military force, and social stability of a given actor, typically a state.[14]

Debates during the postwar years about how food power could help the United States its achieve the goals of stability, prosperity, and security were part of a larger conversation about the role of food in the security of states, communities, and individuals. The absence of sufficient food was clearly recognized as a root cause of conflict and insecurity. For example, in 1962, Orville Freeman, President Kennedy's secretary of agriculture, wrote, "The history of mankind and the records of his wars clearly demonstrate that food is a prime weapon, a prime target, and the prime element of survival."[15] Freeman's attribution of the centrality of food to conflict is part of a long tradition recognizing that food, and the ability to control availability, access, utilization, and stability of food, could be vitally important to the legitimacy and security of states.[16]

In the mid-twentieth century, however, although food was recognized as a root cause of conflict and instability, it was not typically discussed primarily as an issue of national security. Instead, food was seen as a problem that could be solved through the careful application of government

policy to try to balance supply and demand. Policymakers of the time were particularly concerned about the problem of agricultural surpluses. In the postwar period, American agriculture was booming. Farmers were producing much more food than American markets could absorb. So the government stored the excess. The costs of doing this worried officials, who thought that if they could reduce the surpluses, they could reduce the costs of the farm programs while also boosting the incomes of farmers.

A great deal of policy between the late 1940s and early 1970s revolved around efforts to reduce agricultural surpluses. What policymakers at the time did not seem to understand was that even though food was not seen as central to national and international security, the surpluses provided by America, along with allies such as Canada and Australia, helped undergird a thirty-year period of relative stability in global food supplies and prices. From the end of the postwar period until the early 1970s, the huge agricultural surpluses generated by the United States helped to stave off a major global food crisis and provided a powerful tool that could be used in the event of localized need as a result of natural disasters or agricultural failures. Food, though primarily discussed in conversations and policy debates about domestic farm issues, was a critical element of American national power that helped provide stability in a volatile Cold War security environment.

Moreover, in their efforts to unload the surpluses, American officials created new avenues for dispensing food, including aid programs, such as Food for Peace; domestic nutrition-assistance programs; and fallout-shelter-provisioning programs. They aligned food disbursement with national security doctrines, such as containment, in an effort to shore up America's allies during the Cold War and prevent the spread of Soviet power. And they sought to help farmers, from Mexico to India, become more prosperous and productive through the scientific and technical assistance of the Green Revolution. For all of their problems, these programs meant that fewer people around the world went hungry. These efforts also demonstrated the ability to utilize food as a form of assistance to those in need while also establishing the success of the American way in the postwar years. The ability of the United States to dispense food to help those

in need—even the Soviet Union—was something that government leaders would point to again and again as evidence that the American system was superior to communism. Abundance was the foundation of an international food system, and the United States was at its center.[17]

But that postwar system came to an end in the early 1970s. American policymakers had finally managed to eliminate surpluses—not realizing how critical they had become to the security and stability of the United States and the world. Then the world food crisis hit, between 1972 and 1974. The lack of American agricultural surpluses was not the sole cause of the crisis. The early 1970s saw a perfect storm of severe unexpected events, "shocks," which contributed to the food crisis. These shocks included harsh weather in key food-producing regions, a growing global population, and changing food-consumption patterns. Also important were policy decisions, such as President Nixon's agreement to sell massive quantities of American grain to the Soviet Union and his decision to take the United States out of the Bretton Woods system, ending of the direct convertibility of the United States dollar to gold. International politics, such as the 1973 Yom Kippur War and resulting OPEC oil embargo, played a hand as well. Yet, of all of these shocks, a key causal factor of the crisis was the fact that American surpluses were no longer available to cushion the blow. Without these surpluses, the postwar food system collapsed.[18]

This book tells the story of the rise and fall of the American food system from the end of World War II to the early 1970s. It argues that during this period food was central to national security. Although American policymakers were often focused on doing away with surpluses, they constructed a postwar global food system that depended on abundant food supplies that stabilized food prices and ensured food availability. This system was profoundly altered in the early 1970s by the elimination of those surpluses. The resulting conditions—with which we are still living today—are not the centralized system of the postwar period, in which a single actor (the United States) played an outsize role. Instead, it is a global food network, in which no single actor or entity can definitively alter or affect food markets or conditions. It is, as the UK government's Foresight Programme has noted, "not a single entity,

but rather a partially self-organised collection of interacting parts."[19] This distinction between a system and network matters, because much of the thinking about how to solve contemporary world food problems rests on calls to dismantle or reorient today's "food system" to make it more effective in meeting nutritional, economic, social, and environmental goals.[20]

The new world food order that has existed since the 1970s, however, is not a system. It is a network that stretches from farms to forks around the world and includes many activities involved in producing, gathering, harvesting, processing, transporting, preparing, and consuming food. In the United States, for example, almost two-thirds of fruits and vegetables and 80 percent of seafood—in total between 10 percent and 15 percent of all food consumed by American households—is imported.[21] This intertwining has created a network of local, regional, and national food systems that has reshaped the global food landscape. This network emerged in fits and starts, in response to the efforts of a broad range of actors, policies, and events at home and abroad.

The world food network depends on sometimes tenuous connections between far-flung participants and rests on a shared agreement that food is central to the security and prosperity of human societies (even though its constituents vary, sometimes widely, in how and why they envision that to be true). In contrast to the relatively stable, American-driven postwar food system, the contemporary world food network is a complex and ever shifting landscape where states, companies, international organizations, nongovernmental groups, individuals, and communities advance and contest visions of ideal food relationships. Why are food problems, from malnutrition to the sustainability of food production to contamination of the food supply, so challenging to solve, and why are critics' calls for change so hard to implement? In part, it is because the "food network" is, in comparison to a "food system," less responsive to straightforward policy or market-based solutions. Whether food relations are a *system* or a *network* is much more than a question of terminology. It is directly relevant to understanding and addressing food problems and the landscape of solutions.

The concept of a "system" is used in reference to food in two primary ways: first, as a way to trace energy flows, and second, in regard to the role of food in modern political and economic arrangements. The idea of tracing food-energy flows has its origins in the early twentieth-century ideas of Charles Elton. In his 1927 book *Animal Ecology* (1927), Elton described the workings of natural communities in order to enable the more effective management of plant and animal industries. He used the term "food chain," to describe the the flow of energy from plants, which convert sunlight into food, to herbivores and then to the predators that feed on herbivores. Together, all the food chains in an ecological system made up a "food web."[22] Notions of food chains and food webs underlie the understanding of a food system as a series of linked processes through which "raw materials and inputs are turned into edible food products that are consumed by end-users."[23] A "food system" is thus "the entire set of activities and relationships that make up the various food pathways from seed to table and influence 'the how and why and what we eat.' "[24]

A second use of the term "food system" comes from systems theory. Systems theory emerged in the mid-twentieth century as a way to understand complex patterns of interaction in modern political, economic, and technological systems.[25] These ideas were taken up in the 1950s and 1960s by scholars of international relations to refer to "an arrangement of the actors of international politics in which interactions are patterned and identifiable."[26] Terms like *food system, food order*, and *food regime* all refer to just such a "system," in this case the processes and activities that link the production and consumption of food in regular and traceable ways.[27]

Examinations of food systems can occur on multiple scales, from local areas to agro-ecological regions to nations or even to the entire world. The similar emphasis on production and consumption in both ways of describing a food system is not terribly surprising, given that early ecologists leaned heavily on the same set of ideas that saw nature through "the forms, processes, and values of the modern economic order as shaped by technology."[28] Both views of the food system were not only strongly shaped by their reliance on economic order as a critical lens, but also by the sense that agriculture and food production were sets of hierarchical activities

(which can be defined either by energy level or political level) that could be managed by humans in order to produce a desired outcome.[29] The food system, though, is not a single, unified system but rather is a network.

Networks are interconnected systems that allow sharing between systems and contain regularized interactions between nodes of activity. Emerging in the late twentieth century, network theory responds to the sense among scholars that human social, political, economic, and technological systems were changing faster and at greater magnitudes than ever before. The speed of change, and its unprecedented scale, results, at least in part, from the increased interconnectedness of the modern world and the recognition that the "dominant functions and processes in the Information Age are increasingly organized around networks."[30] Theorists have identified the importance of networks in everything from travel to energy to food. Networks are a series of interconnected nodes, and the distance is shorter between two nodes that belong to the same network. The form a node takes may vary depending on the network in question, for example, airports or port facilities in a transportation network or a large-scale farm or major retail distribution centers in the food network. Larger airports or distribution centers represent *hubs* (high-traffic nodes), while smaller airports or individual stores can be understood as *nodes*. Networks thus are patterns of relations that collapse distances and that allow something—be it information, energy, airplanes, or food—to travel rapidly and regularly along the links of the network. Networks, along with an associated set of changes related to globalization and the rise of information technology, have helped to dramatically increase the speed and scale of global interactions.[31]

That speed and scale are part of what makes it difficult to fully comprehend the flows and shifts of the contemporary global food network. Understanding patterns of food relations as a network that exists within and between nations illuminates links that exist between key nodes and hubs. However, it does little good—when understanding the network is the goal—to try and assign a simple hierarchical order to rationalize the increasing speed and scale of global interactions around food. Instead, the complexity, contingency, and co-involvement of conditions and events at

multiple scales of nodes and hubs must be appreciated. To suggest that contemporary food relations are more properly conceptualized as a network than a system does not, however, mean that food problems cannot be addressed and managed. Rather, the complex, interactive structure of the contemporary world food network highlights the fact that management and control, especially by one hub—be it a state, international organization, or company—will be very difficult.

This book seeks to offer an explanation for why the contemporary food network arose in the mid-1970s. It looks back at the system that existed prior to the 1970s, investigating the aims that motivated the American policymaking efforts responsible for its development. In tracing the rise and fall of this postwar system, the book also helps explain contemporary challenges related to ensuring food security, at a time when we are still grappling with the expectations and goals of the postwar food system, even if we are no longer living and working within its parameters. The American focus of this book is not to suggest that actions outside of the United States were not relevant to the postwar food system but is instead an assertion that American actions were central, and often generative, to efforts to bring people and places together through food.

It is also worth noting that although the focus of this book is on the period of roughly 1945 to 1975, the landscape of contemporary food challenges has a number of critical antecedents in the great transformations in food since the end of World War II. Nineteenth-century improvements in transportation, such as the bulding of canal and railroad systems, linked new markets and reduced the time and cost of transporting goods. The rise of large food processors created regional and national food companies, such as Quaker Oats, the National Biscuit Company, W. K. Kellogg, H. J. Heinz Company. The development of the science of nutrition, and changes to farming as it became industrialized also led to major shifts.[32] However, the government's utilization of food as a form of deployable national power to advance national security and national interests deepened in the postwar period. This development was concurrent with, and in many ways enabled by, a range of scientific and technological developments

that allowed for greater productivity and the increasing integration of local, regional, and national food systems with global markets.

One result of these changes is that the importance of food to national and human security has, over the past thirty years, become more widely apparent and more widely discussed. Food-security challenges are, of course, among the oldest problems faced by states; but they took on a distinctive character in the late twentieth century. A further consequence of the intensification and mechanization of agriculture and food production is the increasing interconnection between food, water, and energy systems, an interactivity recognized by the US National Intelligence Council as one of the key megatrends that will shape the world in coming decades.[33] Through the great acceleration in the speed and scale of global interactions around food in the twentieth century, food became more than just a source of calories or a signifier of cultural identity; it served as a critical nexus in the relationship between humans and nature, in which efficiency and productivity were increasingly prioritized.[34]

In response to the negative unintended consequences of agricultural intensification—as well as to concerns about reductions in productivity and rising demands for food—a number of scholars, scientists, activists, and policymakers have identified the impact of agriculture and food production on the environment while also recognizing the need to amplify the positive benefits of intensified agricultural production and to minimize its negative environmental effects.[35] Amid the swirl of problems confronting contemporary world leaders and policymakers, food has emerged as a critical component of the security and prosperity of nations and individuals. But contemporary leaders are not the first to confront needs and wants for food, or to consider that food can be a vital tool in ensuring the stability and flourishing of human societies.

In exploring the use of American food power to promote American national security and national interests, this book investigates a series of roughly chronological moments in the rise and fall of the postwar food system. Chapter 1 examines the plans developed in response to unexpectedly severe and widespread postwar reconstruction and humanitarian crises. Food was central to the both the military effort abroad and on

the home front during the war. and it emerged as a core issue after the war as well, when America was the only country in the world producing more food at the end of the war than at its start. Initial plans for postwar reconstruction in Europe ranged from proposals to deindustrialize Germany and return it to a pastoral state to efforts to provide food and needed material through the continuation of wartime programs and voluntary aid to friendly nations. Only as the Cold War began to take shape did America settle on the Marshall Plan as a way to use American agricultural abundance to both promote postwar reconstruction and serve as a bulwark against communism. More than a quarter of the more than $13 billion that the United States provided for European reconstruction between 1948 and 1953 was either provided in the form of food or was earmarked to aid in rebuilding Europe's agricultural capacity. Widely supported by the American people, the Marshall Plan thus established several trends that would continue through the next several decades: first, American abundance could be used to aid allies, especially (though this was just beginning to be clear in the early 1950s) to stymie the expanding influence of the Soviets; and second, American abundance was increasingly not only an expectation at home, when ending wartime rationing, even amid widespread global hunger, was necessary to boost morale of its citizens, but also a critical element of the American image abroad.

Chapter 2 assesses the "food problem" that arose in the 1950s as Americans faced an unlikely challenge: rising food prices but lower farm incomes. As Americans became more affluent, they spent more rather than less of their income on food, defying the existing economic dogma. In part, this was a result of the increased costs to food companies of food-processing technologies and advertising, which were passed along to consumers, and meant that Americans were paying more for foods having so-called built-in services, such as cake mixes and instant coffee. At the same time, this increased spending on food did not trickle down to farmers, who were earning less of every food dollar, causing concern among policymakers about falling rural prosperity. Above all, *abundance* emerged as a watchword for American prosperity and security in a dangerous Cold War world. The central role of food and the American consumer

society was most dramatically demonstrated in the 1959 Kitchen Debate between American vice president Richard Nixon and Soviet premier Nikita Krushchev, which took place at the American National Exhibition in Moscow. There, more than forty cakes a day were prepared by General Mills employees in official Betty Crocker Kitchens in front of eager Russian audiences, some of whom (contravening the exhibition's regulations) nabbed samples off plates the bakers had put within easy reach.

Even as abundance became emblematic of American agriculture and food at home and abroad, the "farm problem" continued to bedevil policymakers, who worried about the status and votes of American farmers. Chapter 3 considers the efforts to shape farm policy to preserve small-scale farming and eliminate surpluses even as the the modern agricultural revolution was beginning to produce historic and ever-increasing harvests. This abundance presented policymakers with a new problem in world affairs: the challenge of what to do with too much food. President Dwight Eisenhower and his secretary of agriculture Ezra Taft Benson sought to solve the "farm problem" and address surpluses of food production by dismantling Depression-era government farm programs and restoring a free market in agriculture and food production. When those reform efforts were unsuccessful, they tried next to reduce surpluses by deploying them abroad as food aid, a strategy that led to the passage of the 1954 Agricultural Trade Development and Assistance Act, which established the first permanent American organization designed to provide food aid to foreign nations. Their creativity in attempting to reduce the costs of agricultural surplus storage generated the most effective use of "food power" to date—a new system in which America was providing extensive food aid and assistance abroad and, in doing so, inadvertently stabilizing global food markets.

This offensive use of agricultural abundance abroad had a counterpart in the defensive use of food at home. Policymakers in the 1950s also considered ways to utilize American abundance by stockpiling food in preparation for atomic attack. Chapter 4 explores the shelters, foods, and plans that were developed to protect Americans, farms, and livestock from nuclear war. The high cost of shelter construction and stockpiling

programs led the government to pursue an advisory strategy that encouraged Americans to undertake "do-it yourself" efforts to build shelters and fill their shelves. As this chapter shows, even this advisory role required government experts and civil defense planners to consider what sorts of food were best suited for use in shelter environments. But as Americans began to better comprehend the dangers of radioactive fallout and the enormous destructive potential of thermonuclear weapons in the 1950s and early 1960s, enthusiasm for shelters waned. Americans began to feel that the best way to prepare for nuclear war might be to use American abundance to help ensure that nuclear war never occurred at all.

Chapter 5 examines the central role of food in American efforts during the 1960s to promote peace and stability in global affairs. Food aid gained renewed attention and resources from the Kennedy administration, which added humanitarian assistance to goals of American assistance programs. President Lyndon Johnson also eagerly deployed American food power in efforts to promote American security, but chose a more involved approach than Kennedy, seeking to influence the behavior of nations key to American's foreign policy agenda, such as India and Vietnam—by tying the granting of aid to the willingness of their governments to support policies in their own countries that the United States desired. During both the Kennedy and Johnson administrations, a new way to utilize American abundance emerged: deploying not only food but also the knowledge and tools needed to produce food, through a range of technical assistance programs that involved combined efforts of the government, private foundations, and international organizations to promote a "Green Revolution" that sought to peacefully transform the lives of people around the world.

The end of the 1960s brought turbulence in American affairs at home and abroad, and sparked a set of changes that resulted in the first global food crisis since the end of World War II. Through the continued deployment of food as humanitarian assistance; increased export sales to allies, even the Soviet Union; and changes to domestic agricultural policy, the Nixon administration finally succeeded in eliminating agricultural surpluses at home. But the surpluses, long viewed as a problem at home, had been a stabilizing influence on world food supplies and food prices. In